

OnePlus N6

A sensible smartphone in an overcrowded market

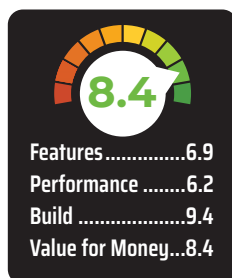
The smartphone market is going through something that we have not seen

before. On one hand, we are seeing massive advancements in hardware, software and AI. On the other hand, rising component costs, memory prices and supply chain uncertainties have made the technology, which was supposed to be accessible, more expensive. This has made it difficult for brands to deliver compelling products without stretching budgets. While flagship devices have absorbed most of the heat, the mid-range segment is now slowly turning into the industry's battleground. Brands are now racing to offer better value, longer battery life and more 'premium experiences' without pushing prices, but honestly, they are just trying. And the latest try comes from OnePlus, which they are calling the OnePlus N6.

Interestingly, the word 'accessible' does not quite show the full picture here. The N6 carries much of the familiar OnePlus DNA, featuring a clean design, sturdy build, large battery and a feature set that appears far more ambitious than what its positioning might suggest. However, capturing the budget-focused smartphone segment is difficult. Competition is fierce, consumer expectations are higher than ever, and OnePlus itself is navigating through its most challenging phase in the Indian market.

Does the OnePlus N6 have what it takes to stand out? Can it deliver the value-first experience that built OnePlus into a global brand that it is?

₹20,000



DISPLAY & DESIGN

The OnePlus N6 comes with a 6.8-inch HD+ IPS LCD display with a 120Hz refresh rate. We are back in the era of LCDs and HD+ resolution displays, with the N6 being the latest addition. But, as I said,

given the market condition, these specs are exactly what many would expect from a phone that starts under Rs 20,000. In terms of quality, the panel is pretty decent. Colours look natural, contrast levels are decent, and the display looks comfortable for activities such as social media browsing, video streaming and casual gaming.

Speaking of the brightness, OnePlus claims a 1,200 nit in High Brightness Mode (HBM). But, during our testing, the phone fell a bit short of that claim, reaching approximately 1,080 nits in

HBM, which is still very close. Importantly, the screen will not disappoint you outdoors, even in direct sunlight. You will still be able to view the display and content easily. However, you may not get the deep blacks and punchier colours that an AMOLED can offer. But again, for this price, the display delivers a practical experience.

Coming to design, the OnePlus N6 definitely looks premium. At first glance, the phone comes with the familiar OnePlus design language, particularly with its camera module, which we have seen in the premium lineup. The build quality also leaves a positive first impression. The device feels solid and reassuringly sturdy in hand, backed by MIL-STD-810H military-grade certification.

OnePlus claims the phone has been tested against extreme temperatures, rain, dust, salt corrosion and multiple drop scenarios. The IP65 rating also adds protection against dust and water exposure.

That said, durability comes with a trade-off. At 224 grams and 8.5mm thick, the OnePlus N6 is noticeably heavier and bulkier than some competitors. You may feel additional weight during prolonged usage, although it appears to be a compromise made to fit in that large 8,000 mAh battery and vapour cooling chamber.

PERFORMANCE

Speaking of performance, the OnePlus N6, on paper, does not immediately stand out against the rivals. The device is powered by the MediaTek Dimensity 6360 Apex chipset and is paired with a 5,300mm² vapour chamber cooling system. While it looks competent, users comparing specs alone may notice that some competitors like Redmi 15 offer better value, at least on paper.

In day-to-day usage, the OnePlus N6 feels smooth and responsive. Social media browsing, messaging, video streaming, web browsing and app switching are handled comfortably